

CROSS-CULTURAL COMMUNICATION

TYRONE T. EDONG
BSDC-3B
04-04-2025

WORKER:

“As a worker belonging to the B’laan community, adjusting to a new workplace culture was not easy for me. Our culture, especially our dialect and the way we communicate, is very different from the majority of the people I work with. One of the main challenges I faced was the difference in language and accent. I noticed that some of my co-workers would make jokes about the way I speak. They would mimic my accent or laugh at certain words I used—not always in a hurtful way, but often without realizing how it made me feel.

For us B’laan, the way we express our thoughts, feelings, and intentions is deeply rooted in our traditions. So when others make fun of it, even as a joke, it feels like they’re laughing at a part of my identity. It made me feel out of place, like I didn’t belong. At first, I became very quiet at work. I avoided conversations with my co-workers and only spoke when needed. I felt that if I talked, I might be judged or misunderstood again.

However, over time, things slowly started to change. Our workplace started having regular team meetings and team-building activities. These gatherings helped open up communication and allowed us to understand each other better—not just as co-workers, but as individuals with different backgrounds. Through these interactions, I started to feel more comfortable. I also made the effort to learn more about their language and how they communicate. I initiated conversations, even small ones, just to bridge the gap.

Little by little, my co-workers also began to understand where I was coming from. Some even became more sensitive and respectful toward my culture. It wasn’t an easy journey, but I’m proud of how far I’ve come. I realized that building connections takes effort from both sides, and through mutual respect and understanding, it’s possible to create a more inclusive and supportive workplace.”

STUDENT

Sometimes, it's really hard for me to communicate with my classmates or teachers, especially when they speak in full Bisaya. There are a lot of Bisaya words that I don't fully understand. So even if I want to express myself or say what's on my mind, I struggle because I don't know how to say it properly in straight Bisaya.

Despite that, I've learned to handle it by trying to get along with them and making an effort to understand their culture. I listen more, observe how they talk, and ask questions when I need help. Over time, it has helped me adjust, even though I still face challenges.

In our Ilonggo culture, nonverbal communication—like gestures, facial expressions, and eye contact—is very important. For example, even when I don't fully understand what someone is saying in Bisaya, I can often tell what they mean through their gestures or tone. That helps me a lot in conversations.

But to be honest, there are times when I feel uncomfortable or left out. Sometimes I feel like others talk behind my back just because I can't understand their language. It makes me feel like they take advantage of that. When I find out that someone is saying something bad about me, I handle it by confronting them respectfully and clearing things up. I believe that communication should go both ways—with respect and understanding.

Being an Ilongga student from Tacurong in Sultan Kudarat, I've realized how important it is to be patient and open-minded. It's not always easy to adjust, but every day is a chance to learn and grow, especially when we learn to respect each other's culture.

APPENDICES

